

Family FEAR

Mainstream parties NC and PDP could well be the frontrunners, but Independents may call the shots

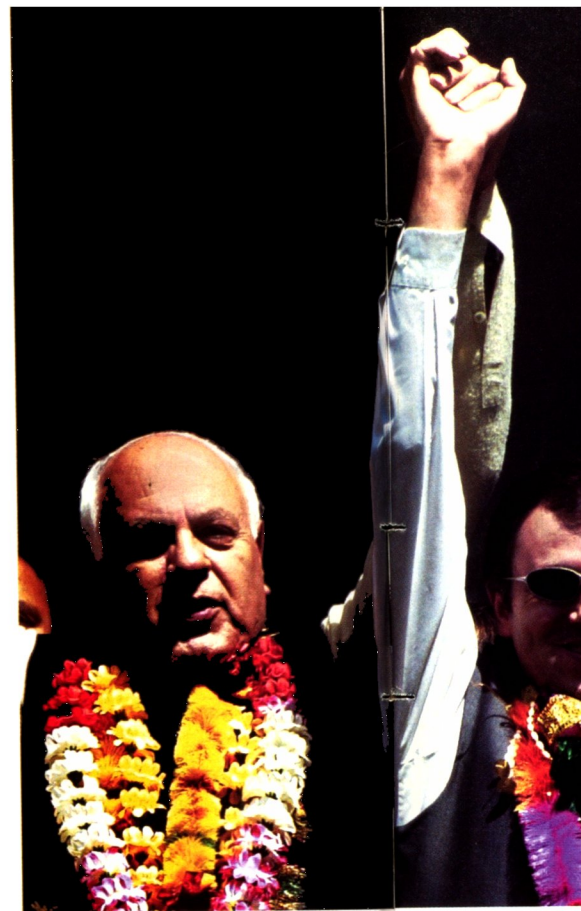
By Aijaz Hussain in Srinagar

With the boycott call from militants and separatists drowning out campaign speeches, the Assembly election in Jammu and Kashmir was expected to be a low turnout affair. The first phase of polls, however, which saw a record 63.75 per cent voter turnout in 10 out of 87 constituencies, generated enthusiasm among the state's mainstream parties. The National Conference (NC) is desperate to come back to power to escape becoming irrelevant in the fast-changing political environment.

THE PDP'S FATHER-DAUGHTER DUO IS OFFERING 'PEACE' FOR POWER

Its arch-rival, the People's Democratic Party (PDP), has positioned itself at the centre of efforts to resolve the Kashmir dispute. The NC has, in turn, muted its autonomy plank, focusing instead on "good governance".

The father-son duo of the NC, patron and chief ministerial candidate Farooq Abdullah and party President Omar Abdullah, are acutely aware that their party's longevity would largely depend on coming back to power. Analysts say the Abdullahs want to retain the party's relevance at the grassroots level, knowing that people never vote for resolution of the Kashmir dispute but for local issues. "Elections are



Photographs by YASIN DAR

not conducted to resolve the Kashmir issue but for solving day-to-day problems of the people," says Farooq.

PDP President Mehbooba Mufti and her father and party patriarch Mufti Mohammed Sayeed talk nothing short of a promise to end the Kashmir conflict. "Sayeed, with his visionary policies, not only delivered good governance but also convinced India and Pakistan to take some concrete steps for restoring peace in this region," says Mehbooba. The Muftis are aware that they have to resurrect their party's image after the Amarnath land row nearly dealt it a death blow. The Abdullahs, by default, have been largely unaffected by the controversy. But the conditions created in the aftermath have forced both parties to adjust their earlier positions. The PDP has graduated from the "healing touch" doctrine of the 2002 elections to the much bigger ambition of being seen as harbingers of peace.

Though the NC appears marginally better placed vis-à-vis the PDP, party insiders say the Abdullahs' main



Mixed HOPE

A single party majority may not be in the interest of the Congress party at the Centre.